



# WHEN TO TAKE A PREGNANCY TEST

## How Pregnancy Tests Work

Pregnancy tests detect the hormone human chorionic gonadotropin (hCG), which is produced after a fertilized egg implants in the uterine lining. As pregnancy progresses, hCG levels rise rapidly, making the hormone detectable in urine or blood.

## When to Test for Best Accuracy

- After a missed period: Most healthcare providers recommend testing the day of or after a missed period for the most reliable result.
- Early testing: Some sensitive tests can detect hCG 10–14 days after conception, but results may be less reliable.
- First morning urine: hCG is more concentrated in the first urine of the day, which can improve test accuracy.
- After fertility treatment: Those undergoing fertility treatments with hCG injections should follow their provider's guidance on when to test.

## Understanding Results

- Positive result: Indicates pregnancy is likely. Follow up with a healthcare provider to confirm and begin prenatal care.
- Negative result with missed period: May indicate testing too early. Retest in 3–5 days or consult a provider.
- False negative: Can occur if the test is taken too early before hCG is detectable.
- False positive: Rare, but can occur after early pregnancy loss or with certain fertility medications containing hCG.
- Faint positive line: May indicate very early pregnancy; repeat testing is recommended.

## When to Seek Medical Evaluation

- Positive test with severe pain or bleeding (rule out ectopic pregnancy)
- Persistent negative results despite missing more than one period
- Uncertainty about results or timing

## Key Takeaway

Identifying the fertile window and timing intercourse accordingly is one of the most effective evidence-based strategies when trying to conceive.

*Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.*

*Educational content informed by Cleveland Clinic. (2022). Pregnancy tests. American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. (n.d.). Especially for teens: Pregnancy tests. Mayo Clinic. (2022). Home pregnancy tests: Can you trust the results?*